

Aconitum napellus (Ranunculaceae)

Aconite, Monkshood

Description Perennial herb growing to 5 ft (1.5 m). Has dark green lobed leaves with violet or blue delphinium-like flowers on long spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Aconite grows mainly in southern and central Europe. It prefers damp and shady sites, and is cultivated as a garden plant. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Aconite contains 0.3–2% terpenoid alkaloids, principally aconitine.

History & Folklore *Aconitum* species have traditionally been used as arrow poisons.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Aconite is poisonous in all but the smallest doses, and is rarely prescribed for internal use. More commonly, it is applied to unbroken skin to relieve pain from bruises or neurological conditions. In Ayurvedic medicine, aconite is used to treat neuralgia, asthma, and heart weakness. Aconite is also used extensively in homeopathy as an analgesic and sedative.

Related Species Chinese aconite (*A. carmichaelii*) is used in China for shock and to support the circulatory system in emergencies. Trials in China indicate that it is helpful in congestive heart failure.

⚠️ Cautions Aconite is highly toxic and is subject to legal restriction in some countries. Use only under professional supervision.

Adhatoda vasica (Acanthaceae)

Malabar Nut, Vasaka

Description Evergreen shrub growing to 10 ft (3 m), with lance-shaped leaves, white or purple flowers, and 4-seeded fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to tropical India, malabar nut grows in low-lying regions up to the Himalayan foothills.

Parts Used Leaves, root, flowers, fruit (nut).

Constituents Malabar nut contains pyroloquinoline alkaloids and an unidentified volatile oil.

History & Folklore The highly bitter-tasting malabar nut is a traditional Ayurvedic remedy for chest problems.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Due to its expectorant qualities, malabar nut is useful for bronchitis and other chest conditions. An Ayurvedic preparation that includes malabar flowers is used to treat tuberculosis. All parts of the plant are used to expel worms. A poultice of the fresh leaves is applied to wounds and to inflamed joints.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.

Adiantum capillus-veneris

(Polypodiaceae)

Maidenhair Fern

Description Fern with delicate fronds growing to 1 ft (30 cm) long.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, Asia, most of the Americas, and Australasia.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Maidenhair fern contains flavonoids (including rutin and isoquercitin), terpenoids (including adiantone), tannin, proanthocyanidins, and mucilage.

History & Folklore Maidenhair fern has been used since ancient times. Pliny the Elder (23–79 CE) states that the herb “is of singular efficacy in expelling and breaking calculi of the bladder.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Commonly used in Latin America and occasionally in Europe, a decoction or tincture of maidenhair fern is used as an expectorant to treat coughs, bronchitis, sore throat, and chronic nasal congestion. The plant has a longstanding reputation as a remedy for conditions affecting the hair and scalp.

Related Species *A. caudatum* has been shown to act as an antispasmodic and could be useful in the treatment of asthma.



Maidenhair fern is used for chest complaints.

Adonis vernalis (Ranunculaceae)

False Hellebore, Yellow Pheasant's Eye

Description Perennial herb growing to 8 in (20 cm). Has a scaly stem and feathery compound leaves. Stem bears large, bright yellow flowers up to 3 in (8 cm) across.



False hellebore's cardiac glycosides help to slow down heart rate.

Habitat & Cultivation Originating from the steppes of Russia and from the Black Sea region, this herb is native to much of Europe but not to Britain. It grows in mountain pasture undergrowth. It is rare and legally protected in Western Europe.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents False hellebore contains cardiac glycosides, including adonitoxin.

History & Folklore False hellebore's botanical name refers to Adonis, a figure in Greek mythology associated with the seasonal renewal of plant life.

Medicinal Actions & Uses False hellebore contains cardiac glycosides similar to those found in foxglove (*Digitalis purpurea*, p. 202). These substances improve the heart's efficiency, increasing its output while at the same time slowing its rate. Unlike foxglove, however, false hellebore's effect on the heart is slightly sedative, and it is generally prescribed for patients with hearts that are beating too fast or irregularly. False hellebore is also recommended as a treatment for certain cases of low blood pressure. In common with other plants containing cardiac glycosides, false hellebore is strongly diuretic and can be used to counter water retention, particularly in cases of poor circulatory function. False hellebore is used in homeopathic medicine as a treatment for angina.

⚠️ Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Gathering wild plants and their medicinal use are subject to legal restrictions in some countries.